Balor Skallfang, The Tainted

Lore & Background: The Undying Scourge War, The Five Generals and The Four Great Orders



ARC I: THE UNDYING SCOURGE

Chapter 1: The Rise of the Monster Legions:

Long before the names of kingdoms were carved into history, the monstrous races of the world lived divided, and the mortal races were beginning their expansion of the outer regions of the continent of Kythoria. The creatures that would one day form the Scourge did not share a common banner, nor a common purpose. They inhabited different corners of the world, competing amongst themselves for territory, resources, and survival. Conflicts between monstrous species were as common as those fought against the mortal races, and few believed that such creatures could ever unite beneath a single military force…

Yet, over time, something unprecedented began to emerge.

Independente warbands slowly grew into disciplined armies. Creatures that had once hunted one another now marched side by side beneath shared banners, giving birth to what history would remember simply as ***The Scourge***.

Unlike the kingdoms of the mortal races, The Scourge did not organize itself through noble bloodlines or political alliances. Its hierarchy was built upon a single principle: **Strength**.

Every position within its ranks had to be earned through victory, and every commander ruled only for as long as they possessed the power to defend that position. At the foundation of the army stood countless independent Warbands, each led by a powerful warlord.

Through centuries of conquest, the strongest warbands absorbed the weakest, gradually growing into vast military formations known as Legions. Despite fighting beneath the same banner, a Warband and a Legion served very different purposes within the Scourge's military structure.

A Warband was the most fundamental military unit of the Scourge. Formed around a single powerful warlord, it consisted of the warriors who had sworn – or been forced – to follow their command. Some warbands numbered only a few dozen creatures, while the greatest could field several hundred. Most were composed of a single dominant species, allowing them to exploit their natural strengths and hunting instincts with ruthless efficiency.

Warbands were expected to wage constant campaigns, conquer territory and challenge rival commanders. Success was rewarded with prestige, resources and most importantly the right to claim the defeated army through the ancient tradition known as **The Gathering of the Spoils**.

As victorious warbands continued to absorb their rivals, they eventually grew beyond the ability of a single commander to lead them as a unified hunting force. At this point they were reorganized into Legions. Unlike warbands, a Legion was not simply a larger army; it was an entire military host.

Each Legion united numerous warbands beneath a single Great General, preserving the independence of individual warlords while coordinating them toward a common military objective. Every warband retained its own identity, traditions and commanding warlord, but all ultimately answered to the General who commanded the Legion.

This structure proved remarkably effective. Rather than forcing wildly different monstrous species into identical formations, the Scourge allowed each warband to fight according to its own strengths while the Legion's command ensured that every assault formed part of a far greater strategy. Creatures that would have been incapable of cooperating on their own became devastatingly efficient when directed by a General capable of orchestrating dozens of warbands simultaneously.

In time, The Five Great Generals came to command multiple Legions and answered only to the supreme command of the Scourge itself. Their names would become synonymous with destruction, and entire civilizations would come to measure the progress of the war by the movements of these five legendary commanders.

Chapter 2: The Five Great Generals

I. Khar'Zul, The Flesh That Remembers



Species:

Balor.

Among the countless Balors that served within the Scourge, only one would rise to become one of the Five Great Generals. That Balor was Khar'Zul.

Title:

Khar'Zul, The Flesh That Remembers

Throughout the centuries of the Scourge War, countless names were given to him by frightened kingdoms and desperate survivors.

None endured longer than the one that followed him until his final battle.

The Flesh That Remembers.

Appearance:

Khar'Zul towered over nearly every creature that marched beneath the Scourge banner. His immense frame was covered in obsidian-black skin, fractured by rivers of molten fire that pulsed beneath the surface like blood through living veins. Vast horns crowned his head, while great wings of scorched membrane cast shadows over entire battlefields.

Unlike many Balors, Khar'Zul carried two legendary weapons into battle. A colossal greatsword, whose name has been lost in history books, forged in the depths of the Abyss, said to be as ancient as the wars themselves. And an abyssal whip of living fire, capable of reducing ranks of soldiers to ash with a single sweep.

Personality:

Khar'Zul possessed an intellect that set him apart from nearly every other creature within the Scourge. Where many of its commanders relied upon overwhelming brutality, Khar'Zul viewed war as an art to be perfected. Every campaign, every siege and every battle became an opportunity to exercise his greatest talent: the calculated destruction of hope.

He rarely raised his voice, rarely acted in anger. His composure never faltered, even amidst the chaos of battle. To those who fought beside him, this calm was often more terrifying than the fury of any beast… for Khar'Zul did not merely seek victory. He sought to ensure that every victory would be remembered and to make sure entire kingdoms were broken longe before their armies were defeated. Cities were left standing just long enough for neighboring realms to witness their fall. Survivors were spared not through mercy, but because fear spread farther than fire ever could.

To Khar'Zul, suffering was not an unfortunate consequence of war… it was one of its most effective weapons.

Philosophy:

Khar'Zul believed that existence itself was governed by a single immutable law.

Strength.

To him, mercy, justice, honor and compassion were temporary illusions created by those incapable of imposing their own will upon the world. Strength was the only truth; everything else merely delayed the inevitable. This belief defined not only how he fought but how he ruled.

Military Command:

Unlike many of his fellow Generals, Khar'Zul rarely relied on overwhelming numbers alone; he believed victory began long before armies met upon the battlefield. Every campaign was meticulously planned, supply routes were cut, escape paths were eliminated, and cities were isolated before they were besieged. Entire kingdoms often surrendered before Khar'Zul himself ever arrived; those who resisted discovered why his name inspired such fear.

Khar’Zul commanded one of the largest Legions ever assembled by the Scourge. Unlike most Legions, which tended to favor particular species or methods of warfare, his forces were composed of an extraordinary diversity of monstrous races. Each warband retained its own commander, traditions and methods of combat.

Under his command, creatures that should never have been capable of coordinated warfare became devastatingly efficient military forces.

Reputation:

Among the mortal races, Khar’Zul became the embodiment of the Scourge itself. Cities abandoned their walls upon hearing his Legion had crossed their borders, and entire kingdoms altered military campaigns simply to avoid confronting him. Within the Scourge, however, he inspired something far rarer than fear… Respect.

Among the Five Great Generals, Khar’Zul earned a reputation unlike any other. He was not regarded as the strongest, nor the most powerful…

He was regarded as the most dangerous.

Fate:

At the climax of the First Great Alliance’s campaign against the Scourge, Khar’Zul was defeated during the greatest battle of the age and became the last of three of the Great Generals to fall.

Unable to destroy his immortal essence, the heroes of the Alliance sealed it within his own greatsword through an ancient ritual, transforming his legendary weapon into a living prison.

II.Voragos, The Ashen Winged Eclipse



Species:

Ancient Black Dragon

Few living creatures could remember a time before Voragos darkened the skies. Even among dragon kind, he was regarded as an ancient relic from a forgotten age. His scales, blacker than volcanic glass, bore the scars of countless wars, while centuries of battle had left his horns fractured and wings torn, yet never weakened.

He was not merely an Ancient Dragon, he was one of the oldest living creatures ever to march beneath the banner of the Scourge.

Title:

The Ashen Winged Eclipse

Over the centuries, kingdoms gave him many names. Some called him **The Black Death of the Skies** and others **The End of Kingdoms**.

Yet history remembers only one...

The Ashen Winged Eclipse.

For wherever Voragos flew... Only ash and darkness remained.

Appearance:

Voragos was an immense Ancient Black Dragon whose size eclipsed nearly every other creature upon the battlefield. His scales resembled polished obsidian, absorbing light rather than reflecting it, while countless scars carved across his body bore witness to centuries of warfare.

Great horns swept backwards from his skull like jagged crowns, broken and reforged by battle after battle. His enormous wings stretched across the battlefield like storm clouds; their weathered membranes stained with soot and ash accumulated through centuries of fire and destruction.

His eyes burned with pitch black darkness, never displaying rage or excitement – only cold certainty.

When Voragos took flight, entire battlefields fell into shadow beneath his wings. Long before his fire reached the ground, his silhouette alone was enough to send armies into retreat.

Personality:

Voragos embodied the raw instinct of an apex predator. He possessed remarkable intelligence, yet rarely concerned himself with politics, strategy or conquest beyond what was necessary to fulfill his role within the Scourge.

War was not a puzzle to solve; it was a hunt. He viewed every battlefield as his domain, every fortress as prey and every army as little more than another challenge to overcome through overwhelming force.

Voragos was fiercely proud, even by draconic standards. He tolerated no weakness, respected only power and considered nearly every living creature beneath his notice. This behavior led to his greatest weakness, his arrogance. Which would eventually lead to his unexpected downfall and a turning point in the war.

Philosophy:

To Voragos, existence belonged to those capable of claiming it. Civilizations were temporary, and kingdoms were fleeting. Walls, castles and armies were nothing more than obstacles destined to crumble beneath creatures stronger than those who built them.

Voragos believed civilization itself was an illusion. The weak built monuments believing they would last forever and the strong reminded them that nothing ever did. He did not destroy out of hatred, nor cruelty but because destruction was the purest expression of dominance.

Military Command:

Among the Five Great Generals, Voragos served as the Scourge's living instrument of annihilation. He was deployed only when conquest ceased to matter.

Entire campaigns changed the moment his Legion entered the battlefield. Rather than prolonged sieges or calculated offensives, Voragos favored relentless aerial assaults designed to shatter every form of organized resistance within hours.

Cities that had withstood months of conventional warfare often fell in a single day beneath his assault. His mere arrival transformed battle plans.

Defensive formations collapsed, supply lines became meaningless, and fortifications became targets rather than protection.

Where Voragos flew… There would be nothing left worth conquering.

Voragos Ashen Legion was built around speed, devastation and overwhelming offensive power. Its ranks were dominated by creatures capable of rapid movement and aerial warfare.

Dragons, Wyverns, Drakes, Manticores, Chimeras, Flying aberrations and monstrous predators from every corner of the world.

Rather than maintaining rigid formations, Voragos encouraged relentless aggression, allowing each warband to exploit its own strengths while directing the Legion's overall advance through sheer battlefield dominance.

The Ashen Legion rarely occupied territory; its purpose was to erase it.

Rise Through The Scourge:

Voragos never sought command. Unlike many warlords who climbed through the hierarchy by challenging rivals and expanding their influence through The Gathering of The Spoils, Voragos cared little for rank or authority. He sought only worthy prey…

As his campaigns grew increasingly catastrophic, defeated warbands willingly submitted to his command rather than challenge him, recognizing that survival beneath his wings offered greater glory than certain death opposing them.

Over centuries, his following grew into one of the largest Legions of the Scourge had ever assembled. His promotion to one of the Five Great Generals was not the result of ambition. It was the inevitable recognition that no other commander could unleash devastation on such an unimaginable scale

Reputation:

Among the mortal races, Voragos became less a creature and more a natural disaster. Entire generations grew up believing that kingdoms did not fall to armies but fell to Voragos.

His appearance alone was enough to trigger mass evacuations long before the first flames reached the horizon. Even the bravest commanders understood that conventional warfare held little meaning once the Ashen Winged Eclipse entered the battlefield.

Within the Scourge, Voragos inspired neither loyalty nor admiration. He inspired fears making respected warlords bow to him.

Fate:

During the early years of the First Great Alliance's Last Stand campaign for the Five Great Generals, Voragos became the Alliance's highest priority.

His relentless assaults had reduced entire kingdoms to ash long before conventional armies could even reach the battlefield. So long as the Ashen Winged Eclipse ruled the skies, no fortress could truly be defended; no army could safely march, and no lasting campaign against the Scourge could ever succeed.

Recognizing that the war could not be won while Voragos still lived, the greatest heroes of the Alliance united their strength in a desperate effort to bring him down. The battle that followed became one of the bloodiest confrontations of the entire Scourge War.

Though victory came at an unimaginable cost, Voragos was ultimately slain, becoming the first of the Five Great Generals to fall. His death marked the first great victory ever achieved against the Scourge. For the first time since the war had begun, the skies belonged to the mortal races once more.

III. Xerathul, The Veiled Eyes of Death



Species:

Lich.

Long before his name became synonymous with death, Xerathul was a mortal scholar whose obsession with arcane knowledge eclipsed every other ambition. Unlike many who sought power to rule kingdoms or command armies, Xerathul pursued only one impossible goal...

To escape death himself.

His relentless pursuit of immortality ultimately transformed him into a Lich, forever binding his soul to phylactery through forbidden necromancy. Freed from the limits of mortality, Xerathul became one of the greatest practitioners of death magic the world

had ever known. Within the Scourge, no other being possessed a deeper understanding of necromancy.

Title:

The Veiled Eyes of Death.

Many believed the veil concealed a face too horrifying for mortal eyes to behold, others claimed it hid a curse capable of killing any who dared meet his gaze.

The truth remained known only to Xerathul himself…

Appearance:

Unlike the towering monstrosities that stood beside him among the Five Great Generals, Xerathul possessed an unnervingly fragile frame. His skeletal body was draped in layered robes of faded black and deep crimson; their ancient fabric embroidered with forgotten runes of necromancy. Tarnished golden ornaments adorned his garments, remnant of a lifelong abandoned.

His face was never seen. A long, weathered veil concealed it entirely, falling from beneath an ornate crown of blackened bone and iron. Only two faint points of pale green light could occasionally be seen through its fabric, where his eyes should have been.

In one hand he carried an ancient staff crowned with a crystal infused by countless imprisoned souls. The other was rarely raised; he had little need for it. For wherever Xerathul walked, the dead marched before him.

Personality:

Among the Five Great Generals, Xerathul was perhaps the most enigmatic. He spoke softly, moved slowly, and rarely displayed emotion. To allies and enemies alike, he appeared utterly composed, as though nothing in existence could disturb him.

Yet beneath that carefully crafted image lay a secret known only to himself. Fear. Not fear of defeat, nor fear of failure, but an overwhelming, all-consuming terror of death.

Everything Xerathul had ever accomplished – his mastery of necromancy, his transformation into a Lich and the vast armies of undead that obeyed his command – had been born from a single desperate desire.

To never face mortality again.

The veil he wore did not conceal monstrous corruption; it concealed the terror that never truly left his eyes.

Philosophy:

To Xerathul, death was not a natural end. It was existence's greatest flaw. Kings accepted it; heroes embraced it, and martyrs welcomed it. Xerathul considered them all fools. He believed that mortality was the greatest weakness any living creature could possess.

Power meant nothing if it could be erased by time and glory meant nothing if death claimed it. Only those who conquered death itself could truly claim mastery over existence. His necromancy was never born from cruelty; it was born from desperation.

Military Command:

Xerathul almost never commanded from the front lines. He remained deep within the hearts of his Legion, surrounded by layers upon layers of undead guardians. Every battlefield became an extension of his will. The fallen of both armies rose to replenish his ranks, ensuring that every victory strengthened his forces while every defeat weakened his enemies.

The fallen of both armies rose to replenish his ranks, ensuring that every victory strengthened his forces while every defeat weakened his enemies. Where other General's measured success through conquered territory Xerathul measured it through attrition.

The longer a battle endured, the stronger his Legion became. He possessed extraordinary tactical awareness, yet every decision ultimately served a single purpose. Keeping himself alive.

He commanded the Grave Legion, an army unlike any other within the Scourge. Its ranks were formed not only by creatures that had willingly pledged themselves to the Scourge, but by the countless dead left behind after every campaign. Fallen soldiers, slain heroes, forgotten kings, ancient beasts. No corpse wasted; his legion advanced with unnatural patience. Unlike living armies, they knew neither exhaustion, fear nor pain.

Rise Through the Scourge:

Unlike many warlords who earned their place through brute strength, Xerathul ascended through necessity. As the Scourge's campaigns expanded across the world, the fallen accumulated faster than even its vast Legion could replace.

Where others saw death… Xerathul saw resources.

His mastery of necromancy transformed catastrophic losses into renewed military strength, allowing entire campaigns to continue without pause.

Reputation:

Among the mortal races, Xerathul became the embodiment of hopelessness. Battles won against the Scourge often lasted only until nightfall. By dawn, the fallen stood once

more beneath his banners. Those slain by Xerathul would one day return to destroy the homes they had once died defending.

Within the Scourge, however, Xerathul inspired a very different kind of respect. Not for his courage. But for his unparalleled command over death itself. Few understood the true reason behind his obsession. Fewer still ever saw lay hidden behind the veil.

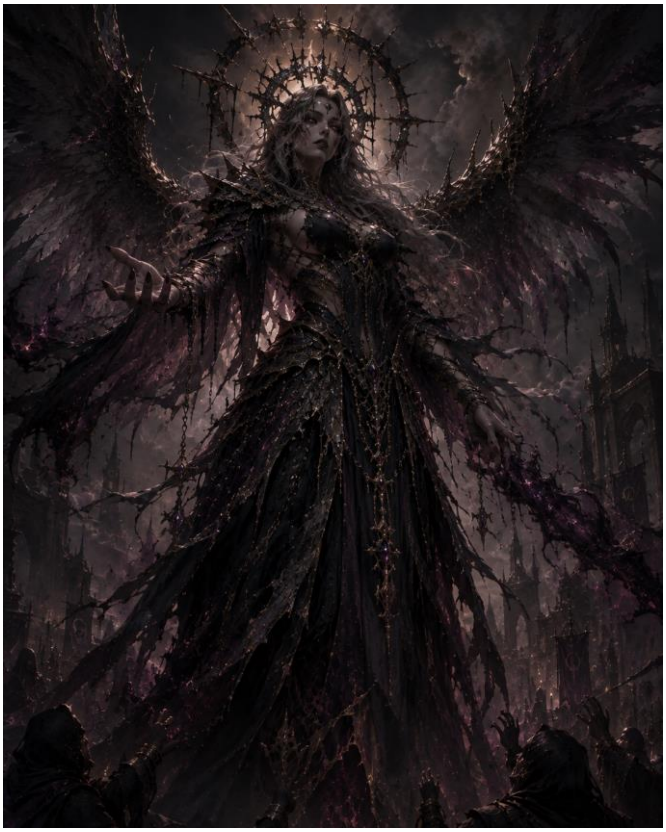
Fate:

Following the fall of Voragos, the first Great Alliance turned its attention toward the master of the Grave Legion. The heroes understood that no lasting victory against the Scourge could ever be achieved while every fallen warrior simply returned to the battlefield.

The campaign against Xerathul became one of relentless pursuit. He refused direct confrontation whenever possible, retreating behind endless ranks of undead while sacrificing thousands of servants to preserve his own existence. Eventually, the Alliance succeeded in breaking through the Grave Legion and reaching the Lich himself.

There were no more dead to stand between Xerathul and mortality. Behind the veil, the composure that had defined him throughout the war finally shattered. The terror he had hidden for so long consumed him in his final moments.

III. Vaessra, The Whisper Before Ruin



Species:

Fallen Empyrean.

Born of divine blood and descended from Vesper, Goddess of Twilight and Harmony, Vaessra was created to embody balance between opposing forces. Where gods often represented absolutes, Vesper governed the fragile equilibrium between light and darkness, peace and conflict, dawn and night.

Vaessra inherited that divine grace. For centuries, she stood as one of the greatest celestial champions of her age, admired not only for her overwhelming strength but for her wisdom, compassion and unwavering presence.

Yet somewhere throughout the endless centuries of the Scourge War, something changed, and whatever transpired has long since been lost to history. All that remains certain is that one day, the daughter of harmony marched beneath the banner of the Scourge.

Title:

The Whisper Before Ruin.

Among the Five Great Generals, none inspired fear quite like Vaessra. Not because kingdoms burned on her arrival, nor because armies vanished before her. They feared her because wherever she walked, ruin always followed.

Entire kingdoms turned against themselves; alliances fractured, faith crumbled; families betrayed one another. Many believed the destruction had begun long before the first monster crossed their borders.

Appearance:

Unlike the monstrous forms of the Great Generals, Vaessra retained much of the divine beauty that had once defined her celestial heritage. Towering above mortals, she possessed an almost ethereal elegance, her presence commanding attention without a single spoken word.

Her skin bore the pale radiance of moonlight, contrasted by long silver-white hair that flowed like liquid light. Behind her rose six magnificent wings. Once brilliant white, their feathers, had gradually darkened into shades of silver, ash and obsidian, as though twilight itself had consumed them.

A fractured halo floated behind her head, cracked yet still emitting a faint celestial glow. Golden armor, forged in an age long forgotten, had blackened with time and corruption; its once pristine engraving now intertwined with dark veins of abyssal energy.

Her eyes remained beautiful, soft, and almost compassionate. Yet with them lingered an unsettling sadness, as though she alone remembered the person she had once been.

Personality:

Among the Five Great Generals, Vaessra was the calmest. She neither sought conquest nor destruction. She rarely raised her voice, displayed anger or even fought unless absolutely necessary. Instead, she listened, observed, and understood. Vaessra possessed a supernatural understanding of emotion, belief, and conviction. She could recognize doubts where others saw loyalty, fear where others saw courage, and ambition where others saw honor. She never needed to force people into darkness; she merely offered them a reason to walk there themselves.

Philosophy:

Vaessra believed that every kingdom carried the seeds of its own downfall: pride, fear, jealousy, faith, love. Every virtue could become a weakness, and every noble ideal could become a weapon. She believed corruption was never imposed, but it was revealed. People did not become monsters because she commanded them to; they became monsters because, given the opportunity… they chose to.

Military Command:

Unlike the other Great Generals, Vaessra rarely commanded through overwhelming force. Her campaigns often began years before open warfare. Her presence cultivated unrest, manipulated political tensions, turned allies into enemies and encouraged distrust between rulers and their peoples. Many kingdoms had already begun collapsing from within long before the Scourge's Legions arrived. By the time armies marched, the war had often already been won.

Vaessra commands the Twilight Legion. Unlike the brutal Legions of the other Generals, her forces were composed of creatures whose purpose was not simply to destroy. They infiltrated, corrupted, and subverted. Her legion included fallen celestials, corrupted champions, monstrous emissaries, shapeshifters, assassins and creatures whose greatest weapon was influence rather than brute strength,

Many battles fought by the Twilight Legion ended before swords were ever drawn.

Rise Through the Scourge:

Vaessra never sought authority, nor did she seize it through conquest. As the Scourge expanded across the world, countless victories were achieved not through military supremacy but through the quiet collapse of kingdoms already weakened by internal division.

Again and again, the same name appeared behind those victories… Vaessra.

Entire nations surrendered without sieges; cities opened their gates willingly, and kings betrayed lifelong allies. Even among the Scourge, few understood how such victories had been achieved. When she was elevated to one of the Five Great Generals, it was not because she commanded the largest Legion.

It was because she had demonstrated a kingdom destroyed from within required far fewer soldiers to conquer.

Reputation:

To the peoples of the world, Vaessra became more myth than General. Unlike Voragos, whose arrival darkened the skies, or Xerathul, whose dead marched openly across the battlefield…

Vaessra often arrived only after everything had already begun falling apart. Some claimed they had heard her voice in dreams; others swore she had stood beside kings disguised as an advisor. Many believe she could never truly be found. Only recognized in hindsight. A common saying emerged during the war…

“When Vaessra is seen, ruin had already begun”

Fate:

Before the First Great Alliance succeeded in bringing Voragos, Vaessra vanished. Without warning, without explanation. Neither the Scourge nor the Alliance understood what had become of her. No battlefield marked her final stand; no body was ever recovered; no betrayal was ever proven. She simply disappeared.

Even the remaining Great Generals offered no answers. To this day, historians continue to debate her fate. Some believe she abandoned the Scourge, others claim she still walks the world beneath another name. Only one fact has ever been universally accepted…

Vaessra, The Whisper Before Ruin, disappeared before the tide of the Scourge War began to turn.

IV. Kha’Thuun, The Witness from Beyond



Species:

Mind Flayer.

Among the countless horrors that marched beneath the banners of the Scourge, few were as alien or as profoundly unsettling as the Illithids. Psionic tyrants and interdimensional voyagers, they viewed sentient life not as equals but as resources to be harvested, studied and ultimately dominated.

While many Mind Flayers sought knowledge to elevate their own colonies, Kha'Thuun pursued something far greater. His mind reached beyond the limits of mortal understanding, delving into truths that no living being was ever meant to witness. Whether those revelations were discovered, inherited or whispered from realms beyond reality has long been forgotten, but by the time the Scourge rose to power, Kha'Thuun had already become the greatest psionic mind within its ranks. His ability to perceive hidden knowledge, unravel secrets and predict the movements of entire civilizations earned him a place among the Five Great Generals.

Title:

The Witness from Beyond.

No title carried by the Great Generals inspired more speculation than that of Kha'Thuun. Throughout the centuries, scholars, priests and kings debated its meaning without ever reaching a consensus. Some believed he had gazed beyond the boundaries of reality itself, witnessing truths no mortal mind could survive.

Others claimed he possessed memories belonging to forgotten worlds or ancient civilizations long erased from existence. None could prove these theories, yet one fact remained undeniable: Kha'Thuun always seemed to know what others believed impossible to know.

Secrets carefully guarded for generations; hidden passages beneath ancient fortresses and battle plans spoken only in private councils somehow found their way into the hands of the Scourge. Whether this knowledge came from his unparalleled psionic abilities or from something far more disturbing, history remembered him by a single name...

Appearance:

Kha'Thuun possessed the unmistakable form of an Illithid, though his presence transcended that of his kin. Towering above most mortals with an unnaturally slender frame, he moved with an almost effortless grace, as though untouched by the physical world around him.

His pale violet skin appeared almost translucent beneath layers of intricately woven black robes embroidered with silver patterns resembling constellations and impossible geometric forms. Four long tentacles hung motionless from his face, rarely twitching unless he spoke directly into another creature's mind. His great obsidian eyes reflected neither emotion nor intent, giving the unsettling impression that they were not looking at those before him, but through them.

Unlike the other Great Generals, Kha'Thuun carried no weapon, no armor and no visible symbol of authority. His mind alone was more dangerous than any blade ever forged.

Personality:

Kha'Thuun rarely spoke aloud, not because he was silent by nature, but because spoken language seemed painfully primitive compared to thought itself. Detached from ordinary emotion, he regarded nearly every creature as an object of observation rather than an individual worthy of judgement. Unlike Khar'Zul, whose mind revolved around conquest, or Vaessra, who understood the hearts of mortals, Kha'Thuun sought only understanding.

He watched civilizations rise and collapse with the same quiet curiosity a scholar might reserve for an experiment. Victory, defeat, loyalty and betrayal held little emotional significance to him; they were simply outcomes to be studied. Conversations with him often left others deeply unsettled, for he possessed an uncanny habit of answering questions before they were spoken or referencing memories that had never been shared.

Philosophy:

To Kha'Thuun, knowledge was the only true form of power. Strength could be overcome; kingdoms would inevitably crumble, and even immortality could be undone, but knowledge endured beyond all of them. Every war was won long before the first sword was drawn, not through courage or numbers, but through understanding.

Those who possessed complete knowledge could shape the future itself, while those who acted in ignorance merely fulfilled destinies they could not perceive. Mortals believed themselves free to choose their path, yet Kha'Thuun saw every decision as another predictable consequence of information they lacked.

His obsession was never domination for its own sake. It was the endless pursuit of truth, no matter how incomprehensible or horrifying that truth might become.

Military Command:

Unlike the other Great Generals, Kha'Thuun almost never commanded armies directly. His role within the Scourge was not to lead charges or besiege cities, but to ensure that every campaign began with overwhelming informational superiority.

While the Black Legion gathered intelligence across the world, Kha'Thuun pieced together countless fragments into a complete understanding of his enemies. He identified weaknesses in kingdoms before their rules recognized them, uncovered hidden alliances before they were formed, and predicted military movements with astonishing precision.

By the time Khar'Zul planned a campaign, Voragos selected his target or Vaessra entered diplomatic negotiations, Kha'Thuun had already revealed every secret worth knowing. To

the Scourge, knowledge was not merely support for war. It was the foundation upon which every victory was built.

Kha’Thuun commanded the Black Legion, the smallest yet arguably most indispensable force within the Scourge. Unlike the vast military formations of the other Great Generals, the Black Legion was composed of highly specialized operatives whose value lay not in overwhelming strength but in the information they could obtain. Mind Flayers, Intellect Devourers, psionic aberrations and other creatures gifted with extraordinary mental abilities formed its core, travelling far beyond the front lines in search of forgotten libraries, ancient relics, hidden civilizations and military intelligence. Entire campaigns depended upon the discoveries made by the Black Legion, for every secret they uncovered became another weapon placed in the hands of the Scourge, To Kha’Thuun, a single forgotten truth was often worth more than ten thousand soldiers.

Rise Through the Scourge:

Unlike the other Great Generals, Kha'Thuun never sought influence through conquest, destruction or political ambition. His rise was almost imperceptible. As the Scourge expanded across the world, impossible victories accumulated with increasing frequency. Kingdoms found their hidden supply routes exposed. Secret fortifications were bypassed with uncanny accuracy. Alliances collapsed before they could even unite against the enemy.

Again and again, these triumphs traced back to knowledge that should never have been available. Eventually even the leaders of the Scourge came to recognize that every successful campaign relied upon the same unseen architect. When Kha'Thuun was elevated to the rank of Great General, it was not because he inspired armies or sought authority, but because the Scourge had come to understand a simple truth: every war was easier to win when one side already knew everything.

Reputation:

Among the people of the world, Kha'Thuun inspired a uniquely unsettling fear. Unlike Voragos, whose shadow darkened the skies, or Xerathul, whose undead marched openly across battlefields, Kha'Thuun often remained unseen throughout entire campaigns.

Yet kings trusted their advisors less; generals abandoned carefully prepared strategies and scholars destroyed their own writings rather than risk them falling into unknown hands. It became widely believed that no secret remained hidden forever, for somewhere beyond the reach of mortal understanding; the Witness from Beyond was already watching.

Even within the Scourge, the other Great Generals rarely questioned how Kha'Thuun obtained his knowledge. They simply accepted that whenever he spoke, he was almost always correct.

Fate:

Unlike Voragos, Xerathul and Khar'Zul, Kha'Thuun was never defeated. As the Scourge gradually lost ground across the world, the Witness from Beyond disappeared without warning, leaving behind neither explanation nor trace of his departure.

No final battle was ever recorded; no body recovered, and no reliable witness could account for his fate. Some believed he had foreseen the inevitable decline of the Scourge centuries before it occurred and simply departed once its purpose had been fulfilled.

Others whispered that his search for forbidden knowledge had led him beyond the boundaries of the mortal world altogether. Whatever the truth may be, history records only one certainty. Like Vaessra before him, Kha'Thuun vanished from history, and with him disappeared countless secrets that perhaps were never meant to be known.

Chapter 3: Khar’Zul’s Rise

The Gathering of the Spoils

For centuries, the armies of the Scourge had followed an ancient tradition known as The Gathering of the Spoils. The Scourge was never a single army in the traditional sense. Its forces were composed of countless creatures, each born from different forms of darkness and possessing their own instincts, methods of warfare, and ambitions. Armies rose and fell beneath the command of countless warlords, and when one commander proved too weak to hold their forces together, another could challenge them.

The Gathering of the Spoils was the ancient law that governed such conflicts. When two great war generals sought to claim one another’s forces, neither was permitted to simply overwhelm the other through numbers. Instead, their leaders would meet in single combat. No armies. No champions. No interference. Two warriors entered and one warrior left.

The victor claimed the defeated general’s forces as their own. To the Scourge, the fallen army was not destroyed. It became spoils – soldiers without a master, waiting for a stronger will to give hem purpose once more. The tradition served more than ritual. It ensured that the armies of the Scourge remained in the hands of those capable of commanding them. Strength earned obedience, while weakness invited replacement. But victory through the Gathering offered more than command.

Every defeated general left behind soldiers, weapons, territories, knowledge and creatures willing – or forced – to serve whoever had proven themselves worthy. Over centuries, some warlords accumulated large enough forces to rival kingdoms. And among all of those who rose through the Gathering, few would leave behind a name as feared as **Khar'Zul...**

Before the Name

Long before Khar'Zul became one of the Great Generals, he was simply another creature fighting within the endless wars of the Scourge. He was a Balor – ancient even by the standards of his kind, possessing the strength, brutality and destructive nature expected of such a creature. Balors were already feared as commanders and instruments of war, and Khar'Zul was no exception.

But raw strength was never what separated Khar'Zul from the creatures around him. He watched. Where other demons saw battlefields, Khar'Zul saw patterns. Where others saw enemies, he saw weaknesses. He learned how different creatures fought, how they reacted to fear, what drove them forward, and what caused them to break.

He did not rush into battle simply because he could. He waited, he observed. And when he finally acted, it was usually because he had already considered what would happen several steps ahead. This made him unusual among the Scourge; Khar'Zul not only enjoyed the chaos of battle but also saw war as a puzzle to be solved.

The First Gathering

Khar'zul's rise began when he challenged Morgath, The Red Maw, another ancient Balor, and one of the Scourge's most feared warlords. Vorgath was everything the Scourge expected from a demon commander: brutal, overwhelming and convinced that strength alone was enough to win a war. His armies were infamous for crushing their enemies through sheer force, leaving nothing but ruins behind.

Khar'Zul had watched his campaigns for years. He saw what others did not: Morgath wasted soldiers, resources and opportunities simply because he possessed the strength to do so. To Khar'Zul, that was not power. It was inefficiency.

The two Balor met alone upon a battlefield surrounded by their armies. Morgath expected a contest of strength. Instead, Khar'Zul studied him. Every movement, every attack, every opening was observed and remembered. What appeared to be a desperate struggle was, in truth, Khar'Zul learning exactly how his opponent fought. When Morgath finally committed to a decisive strike, Khar'Zul stepped into the attack and exploited the weakness he had been waiting for.

Morgath fell, with his torso split from his legs…

By the law of the Gathering, his army became Khar'Zul's spoils.

Thousands of creatures now stood before the Balor who had defeated their former master not through strength, but through understanding. That victory marked the beginning of Khar'Zul's rise. From then on, his reputation spread throughout the Scourge. He was no longer simply a powerful Balor.

He was a commander who learned from everything he fought.

The Name That Spread

With every victory, Khar'Zul's forces grew. With every defeated warlord, another army was added to his own. Some commanders challenged him believing that defeating one Balor would simply mean taking his place. They quickly learned that defeating Khar'Zul on the battlefield was not enough. They had to understand him first, and very few every did…

Stories began spreading among the Scourge. Some claimed that he could look at a battlefield and already know where the dead would fall. Others simply spoke of him as an ancient monster who had learned to think like something far more dangerous than a demon.

The stories grew with every campaign… so did the fear. Eventually, his name became more than the name of a commander. Khar'Zul became a warning. When the battlefield was unusually quiet, commanders wondered whether he was watching. When an enemy's army retreated too easily, they wondered whether it was a trap. When a settlement was spared while everything around it burned, people began asking themselves why.

And when the answer was eventually discovered, it was often worse than if Khar'Zul had simply destroyed everything…

The Flesh That Remembers

Khar'Zul's greatest advantage was not simply his strength, nor his mastery of war. It was the fact that death could not keep him dead.

For centuries, Khar'Zul waged war across the continent of Kythoria, becoming one of the most feared figures within the Scourge. His victories accumulated, his reputation grew, and countless enemies fell before him. Yet despite all who opposed him, none had ever truly managed to bring about his end.

That changed when the Last Stand's Great Alliance was formed with a single purpose: to destroy The Five Great Generals and turn the tides of war in favor of the mortal races.

After felling Voragos and Xerathul, a party was formed to destroy Khar'Zul. After a devastating confrontation, the Alliance finally succeeded in bringing down the ancient Balor… but his death did not last.

His essence returned to the Abyss, carrying with it every memory of the life he had lived and every battle he had fought. Eventually, a new body formed around that same ancient essence.

Khar'Zul had returned and with his return came a terrifying realization for the world. Killing him was not enough. It was after his first death and return that the idea of sealing Khar'Zul within his own sword was conceived – a way to imprison his essence and prevent him from simply returning to the world once more.

The Gathering of Generals

Eventually, Khar'Zul had accumulated enough victories that other warlords could no longer ignore him. He had become something different from the countless commanders who rose and fell within the Scourge. He had armies large enough to threaten established powers. He had defeated generals who had once been considered untouchable. More importantly, his forces had become frighteningly coordinated under his command.

The Gathering of the Spoils allowed Khar'Zul to rise through the ranks. But it was not the tradition itself that made him powerful. It was what he did with every victory. Each defeated commander gave him another army, each army gave him knowledge, each campaign gave him another lesson, and every lesson made the next victory easier.

Eventually, the name of Khar'Zul reached the highest rank of the Scourge. There, he was no longer merely a warlord. He was recognized as one of the Great Generals. One of the five figures entrusted with commanding vast portions of the Scourge's forces. The creature who had once entered a Gathering alone now stood among the most feared commanders in the entire war.

But Khar'Zul did not see his rise as an accomplishment. To him, power was not something to be admired. Power was something to be used…

The Mind Behind the Monster

Khar'Zul remained calm even when surrounded by death. He rarely raised his voice and rarely allowed anger to dictate his actions. Unlike many of the creatures beneath him, he did not need to prove that he was powerful; he already knew that he was.

What interested him was understanding. Understanding his enemies and allies. Understanding fear and suffering. And, above all, understanding how far a creature could be pushed before it broke. Khar'Zul did not simply enjoy causing pain. He enjoyed designing it.

A meaningless slaughter held little interest for him when a carefully constructed sequence of events could cause far greater suffering. A victory was satisfying but a victory in which the enemy unknowingly walked into a trap that had been prepared for days; months or even years earlier was something else entirely.

It was proof of control. That was what Khar'Zul truly valued. Control over the battlefield, control over his armies, control over his enemies, control over himself. And that was why even other creatures of the Scourge feared him.

The General

By the time Khar'Zul had become one of the five Great Generals, there was no doubt that he stood among the most powerful creatures in the Scourge. He possessed the raw destructive power expected of a Balor, a natural talent for violence and devastation that required neither training nor refinement. Destruction came to him instinctively.

But power alone was never what elevated Khar'Zul to the position he held. Of all the Great Generals, Khar'Zul was arguably the one who had fought the hardest to reach that place. He clawed his way through the ranks of the Scourge through centuries of warfare, constantly challenging stronger enemies, learning from every conflict and refining every victory.

His immortality gave him something few others possessed: time.

Whenever his body was destroyed, his essence endured. And when he eventually returned, he carried everything he had learned with him. Every battlefield, every enemy, every mistake and every victory became another piece of knowledge added to the creature he was becoming.

His intelligence was not a gift he was simply born with… He built it.

Khar'Zul studied warfare because he wanted to understand it. He studied his enemies because he wanted to overcome them. He learned to recognize patterns, exploit weaknesses, manipulate the battlefield, and turn even the smallest advantage into victory.

Over centuries, that relentless pursuit transformed him into a master tactician. Where other generals could rely on overwhelming power, Khar'Zul learned to make his power meaningful. Where other saw armies, he saw pieces. Where others saw battles, he saw possibilities. And where others relied on instinct, Khar'Zul relied on understanding. He

was every bit as powerful as the other Great Generals. But unlike some of them, Khar'Zul did not simply inherit his position through overwhelming natural ability.

He earned it.

His strength made him dangerous, and his immortality made him relentless.

Chapter 4: The Great Alliance and The Fall of Khar'Zul

The Great Alliance

The Great Alliance was established by the mortal races as a united effort to push back against the Scourge and begin the long process of reclaiming the lands that had been lost throughout the centuries of war.

Kings, nobles, military leaders, mages, monster hunters and others influential figures from across the mortal realms came together under a common cause. Among its members were representatives of the great monster-hunting orders, the Thormvuld family, powerful spellcasters and members of the nobility.

The Alliance would go on to achieve what seemed impossible for generations.

Voragos was defeated and later, Xerathul was brought down as well.

With two of the five Great Generals fallen, the victories of the Great Alliance became a turning point in the war. The mortal races had proven that the greatest leaders of the Scourge could be challenged and defeated...

But the biggest threat remained...

Khar'Zul.

Unlike Voragos and Xerathul, Khar'Zul presented a completely different kind of threat. He possessed overwhelming power, centuries of experience, and an intellect that had been forged through a lifetime of warfare. More importantly, his immortality meant that even death might not be enough to stop him.

When the time finally came to confront him, the Great Alliance selected a specific groupd from among its ranks to carry out the attack:

Lord Alaric Arkwright – A paladin of noble descent from the families that rule the Last Stand.

Ragnulf Skallfang – At the time, the barbarian chieftain of the Skallfang Clan already known for being deadly monster hunters and an ancestor to Hrothgar Skallfang.

Garrik Thormvuld – An ancestor of the Thormvuld family and an already established great arcane engineer who helped create the seal and vault of Khar'Zul's sword.

Mordrane Vhalor – An old counsellor and prolific wizard and researcher who created the Sealing Ritual of Khar'Zul and defected to the Crimson Covenant after the battle.

Soren Kaien – The monk leader of the Jade Wardens who looked over the East border of the continent.

Edmund Drake – The dragonborn artificer captain of the maritime forces of the Tidebound Brotherhood.

Cassian Aurelius – The cleric half-elf maximus of the researchers of The Sunforged Legion.

Together, they were entrusted with the task of doing what the armies of the Great Alliance could not do alone:

Bring down Khar'Zul.

The First Battle Against Khar'Zul

The Great Alliance eventually tracked Khar'Zul to a major Scourge stronghold. The battle was unlike anything they had anticipated. Khar'Zul was not merely a monster surrounded by an army. He commanded the battlefield himself, constantly adapting to the Alliance's strategies and exploiting weaknesses within their formation.

Every time they believed they had forced him into a disadvantage, he found another way to turn the battle around. The Alliance suffered devastating losses, including the death of two of the Great Order leaders: Soren Kaien and Edmund Drake. Yet for the first time, Khar'Zul found himself facing opponents who could match him not only in strength, but in coordination.

The monster hunters of the Skallfang and the other Orders knew how to fight creatures like him.

Garrik Thormvuld found ways to disrupt his movement and infernal abilities.

Mordrane Vhalor recognized patterns in Khar'Zul's behavior that others missed.

And their leader, the paladin Lord Alaric, kept the entire force together even as the battle descended into chaos.

Eventually, after an immense struggle and countless losses, the ancient Balor was defeated.

Khar'Zul fell.

The battlefield fell silent.

The Alliance believed they had accomplished what generations before them had failed to do…

But they were wrong.

The First Return

The Alliance had done what no army before them had managed to accomplish. The ancient Balor lay motionless among the ruins; his massive form reduced to ash and burning fragments.

Then something went wrong; the remains of Khar'Zul did not simply fade. The ash began to **move against the wind**. Blackened fragments of flesh lifted from the ground and spiraled toward the place where his body had fallen. The air around the battlefield grew unnaturally hot, while the ground beneath the ruins began to crack with faint, crimson light.

The Alliance watched as the remains were drawn together into a swirling mass of smoke, blood, and infernal energy.

And then they were gone.

Not destroyed.

Taken.

For a few moments, nothing happened. Then, from somewhere far beyond the battlefield, a deep infernal roar echoed through the air. The Alliance had no way of knowing where Khar'Zul had gone.

But they knew one thing.

He was not dead.

What they had witnessed was the remains of his physical form being pulled back toward the Abyss, where his essence would endure until it could once again manifest in a body.

What they had witnessed was the remains of his physical form being pulled back toward the Abyss, where his essence would endure until it could once again manifest a body. Their victory had lasted only moments. They had killed Khar'Zul, but they had not ended him.

And when the Alliance eventually learned that Khar'Zul had returned to the world, the truth became impossible to ignore…

Khar'Zul was immortal

The Birth of the Sealing Ritual

The discovery forced the Alliance to confront a problem none of them had anticipated. If Khar'Zul's essence could survive the destruction of his body, then defeating him again would only delay his return.

They needed to find a way to contain the essence itself. Their search eventually led them to an unlikely possibility. Khar'Zul's sword had been at his side throughout centuries of warfare. It had crossed battlefields with him, survived his conquests and served as the instrument through which countless lives had been taken.

It was not magically bound to him, but it had endured centuries of exposure to his power, his violence and the evil carried through his reign.

Mordrane Vhalor and his followers theorized that such an object might possess the strength necessary to withstand an essence as powerful as Khar'Zul's. Not because it belonged to him but because nothing else had endured Khar'Zul for so long.

The theory was considered dangerous, perhaps even impossible but after witnessing Khar'Zul return from death, the Alliance could no longer afford to dismiss impossible ideas.

And so, the foundation of the sealing ritual was born.

The Final Battle Against Khar'Zul

The Alliance confronted Khar'Zul once more. This time, they came prepared. The battle became a war within a war. While the armies of the Last Stand fought to prevent the Scourge from overwhelming them, the members of the Great Alliance fought directly against Khar'Zul.

He was stronger than before: Smarter, more cautious. He understood many of their methods because he had already fought them once. The Alliance understood this as well.

The battle became a contest between Khar'Zul's centuries of experience and the combined knowledge of those who had spent years preparing specifically for this moment. Eventually, the Alliance managed to bring him down once more. But this time, they were ready...

The moment Khar'Zul's physical form began to collapse, the Garrik Thormvuld's devices activated, anchoring the surrounding energy and preventing the essence from escaping and allowing Mordrane Vhalor to begin the ritual.

Khar'Zul's essence resisted.

The sword itself began to react as the ancient power of its master was drawn toward it. The Alliance fought to maintain the ritual while Khar'Zul fought to break free. The sword became the center of the battlefield and when the ritual reached its climax, the essence of Khar'Zul was finally dragged into the weapon that had once belonged to him.

The sealing was successful.

He had become imprisoned within it.

The Fate of the Sword

After the battle, the sword was not destroyed. That was impossible.

It had now become the prison containing Khar'Zul's essence, and destroying the weapon risked releasing the very thing the Alliance had sacrificed so much to contain. Instead, the sword was placed somewhere specifically constructed to keep it isolated from the world.

A heavily guarded vault was established under the protection of the Last Stand, with Thormvuld technology and magical wards designed to prevent the sword from being accessed or transported without the knowledge of the Alliance's remaining guardians. For generations, the sword remained there...

Hidden.

Guarded.

Forgotten by most of the world.

But not everyone...

The Beginning of the Crimson Covenant

Among the members of the Great Alliance was Mordrane, the arcanist who had helped develop the ritual that imprisoned Khar'Zul within his own blade. To the world, Mordrane had been one of the heroes who helped bring an end to one of the Scourge's greatest generals.

But to Mordrane, the sealing had revealed something far greater. Khar'Zul had died. And yet, he had not truly ceased to exist. His essence had survived the destruction of his body, carrying with it everything he had been: his memories, his power, his will, and the

accumulated force of centuries spent conquering and destroying. The ritual had proven that the essence of a being could be separated from its physical form and contained within a vessel.

But Mordrane became obsessed with another realization.

Khar'Zul had changed.

Centuries imprisoned within the blade had transformed the ancient Balor into something beyond what he had once been. His essence had endured without a body, growing into something that could no longer be defined simply as a demon.

Something greater…

Something that should not have been possible….

Mordrane began to question what would happen if such an essence were given a body capable of containing it. Not a body created by nature. A body created by design. His studies eventually led him to the forbidden knowledge that led to the origin of **Project Genesis**, the experiments that had produced the Tieflings — beings created through the deliberate manipulation of mortal and supernatural forces, through years of bloodline manipulation of different races…

To Mordrane, Genesis represented the missing piece.

If Khar'Zul's essence could be preserved and if a body could be created specifically to contain such an essence, then perhaps the two could be combined into something far beyond either of them. Mordrane no longer sought to resurrect Khar'Zul…

He sought to **surpass him**.

He envisioned the creation of the ultimate weapon: a perfect host capable of carrying Khar'Zul's ascended essence while possessing a body designed to grow, adapt, and withstand powers no ordinary mortal could ever contain.

A living vessel.

A weapon born from the union of ancient demonic power and the perfection sought through Project Genesis.

And if such a being could be created, Mordrane believed it would possess the power to do more than defeat the Scourge.

It could reshape the world itself.

Mordrane became convinced that the history of Kythoria had been written by those who merely survived its horrors. Kings, empires, religions and mortal races had spent centuries reacting to the forces that shaped their world.

He intended to change that.

He would rewrite history itself.

The Crimson Covenant was born from this belief.

Those who followed Mordrane abandoned the Great Alliance and disappeared from its history, taking with them the knowledge they had gathered during the war. Over time, their movement became devoted to forbidden knowledge, the manipulation of supernatural essence, and the creation of a vessel capable of carrying Khar'Zul's power.

Their ultimate purpose became clear:

Create the ultimate weapon.
Give form to Khar'Zul's ascended essence.
And use that power to tear down the world that existed and rebuild it according to Mordrane's vision.

But one problem remained.

Khar'Zul was still imprisoned.

The sword was the only vessel that had ever successfully contained his essence — the ancient weapon that had carried his power through centuries of conquest and destruction.

So, the Crimson Covenant began searching for it.

Mordrane maintained an intricate network of spies within the Great Alliance, patiently waiting for the opportunity to reclaim the weapon. Eventually, that opportunity came. The sword disappeared from the custody of those who had guarded it. The Last Stand believed that Khar'Zul's prison had been lost.

It had not. It had fallen into the hands of those who had spent generations seeking the knowledge hidden within it. And inside the blade, something ancient remained…

Khar'Zul remembered.

ARC II: THE FOUR GREAT FRONTIER ORDERS

The Four Great Frontier Orders are the primary forces responsible for protecting the borders of Kythoria from the monstrous lands beyond civilization. Each order developed independently according to the environment it inhabits. The monsters it faces, and the culture of the people who founded it.

Although their methods and beliefs differ greatly, all four serve the same fundamental purpose:

To stand between civilization and the creatures beyond it.

They are not unified under a single command. Each order governs its own territory, maintains its own traditions, and answers its own leadership. Their differences are often a source of rivalry, but centuries of war have forged a mutual respect between them.

Chapter 1: The North - The Skallfang Clan

Territory

The northern frontier of Kythoria, where civilized lands gradually give way to vast frozen wilderness and the deadliest monster-infested territories. The Skallfang settlements are scattered throughout this frontier rather than concentrated in a single great city. Their primary strongholds are built around defensible positions, hunting grounds, mountain passes, and ancient monster trails.

Their largest settlement serves as the heart of the Clan, Ulfrheim, where warriors gather; young hunters train, elders preserve their history, and the current leader holds council. The Skallfang do not attempt to completely tame the northern wilderness. They have learned to live alongside it. Their territory is a constant border between civilization and the monstrous lands beyond.

Culture

The Skallfang are a northern warrior culture shaped by generations of surviving against monsters. Despite their reputation as fierce warriors, they are not simply barbarians...

Their society values discipline, community, knowledge of the wilderness and the ability to understand the creatures they hunt. A Skallfang warrior is expected to know more than how to swing a weapon. They must know how to track monsters, identify their weaknesses, survive harsh environments, protect their companions, recognize monster territories, understand signs of an approaching threat and know when fighting is necessary and when survival requires retreat.

The Clan considers experience one of the greatest forms of knowledge. The oldest hunters are therefore not simply respected because of their age, but because of everything they have survived.

Philosophy

The Skallfang believe that strength has meaning only when it is used to protect others. They do not seek glory through monster hunting; a monster killed in the wilderness is simply one less threat reaching a village.

Their greatest victories are often the ones that nobody remembers: A caravan that arrives safely, a village that never gets attacked, a child who grows up without ever seeing the creature that was killed before it reached their home...

Strength is not measured by what you can destroy, but by what you refuse to let be destroyed.

This philosophy is particularly important to Balor's upbringing and is one of the reasons Hrothgar's teachings remain fundamental to him.

The Three Oaths

WHEN DARKNESS COMES... WE STAND

WHEN DARKNESS GROWS... WE HUNT

WHEN DARKNESS FALLS... WE REMAIN

The Trial of The Fang

Every Skallfang warrior must eventually undergo The Trial of The Fang. The Trial marks the transition from youth into a true warrior of the Skallfang.

Alone, each initiate is sent into the frozen wilderness to overcome a challenge worthy of remembrance. Some return after slaying a great beast. Others survive impossible odds or rescue that which was thought to be lost. They are sent into a path of fate, decided only by the gods... but the deed itself is never what matters most. It is the strength of character revealed through it.

After completing the trial, the warrior receives a byname – a name earned through their actions.

Balor received:

The Tainted.

Attitude

Skallfang tend to be direct, reserved around strangers, fiercely loyal, suspicious of outsiders, practical, resilient, protective and deeply respectful of experience. They generally dislike unnecessary displays of wealth or status. A nobleman who has never faced a monster has little authority in the eyes of a Skallfang hunter. An old hunter who has saved dozens of lives may command the respect of the entire clan.

Most Common Classes:

Barbarians

Rangers

Fighters

Clerics

Weapons & Equipment

Skallfang equipment is designed around survival and practicality. Their weapons tend to favor axes, spears, great weapons, bows, hunting knives, shields, and weapons specifically adapted to fighting large monsters.

Armor is generally practical rather than decorative. Fur, leather, metal plates, and monster components are commonly incorporated into their equipment. A particularly accomplished hunter may carry pieces of a creature they defeated – not purely as trophies, but as reminders of what they survived.

Relationship With Monsters

The Skallfang understand something that many civilized people do not, not every monster behaves the same way. They study creatures and learn their habits, territories, hunting patterns and weaknesses. Some monsters are immediately hostile; others can be avoided. Some may even coexist with settlements if properly understood. This knowledge makes the Skallfang particularly effective against intelligent or highly territorial creatures. They do not fight monsters simply because they are monsters. They fight them when they represent a threat.

Current Leader

Hjalvar Skallfang

Hjalvar Skallfang is the son of Hrothgar and the current leader of the Skallfang Clan. He grew up alongside Balor in Ulfrheim, and throughout their childhood the two became the closest thing either would have to brothers. They trained together, hunted together,

fought alongside one another, and constantly competed to see who could become the stronger warrior.

Their rivalry was never born from hatred. It was built on mutual respect. Hjalvar knew Balor better than almost anyone. He understood his temper, his strengths and his weaknesses, and was one of the few people capable of standing against him in training without fear. Balor, in turn, respected Hjalvar not only as a warrior, but as someone who could challenge him without ever trying to diminish him.

Where Balor's path was increasingly shaped by the strange power within him, Hjalvar remained deeply connected to the teachings of his father and the traditions of the Skallfang. When Hrothgar died during the attack on Ulfrheim, Hjalvar inherited the mantle of **Chieftain of the Skallfang**.

His father's death and Balor's first wielding of Khar'Zul became inseparable memories for him — the night his father died, his home was destroyed, and the brother he had grown up with walked away carrying a power none of them understood. Despite everything that happened that night, Hjalvar never came to see Balor as an enemy. Their paths simply became different.

As Chief, Hjalvar carries the responsibility of protecting the Skallfang and preserving everything his father spent his life building. And somewhere within him remains the same young warrior who once stood beside Balor, competing with him beneath the northern sky.



Chapter 2: The East – The Jade Wardens

Territory

The Jade Wardens inhabit the eastern regions of Kythoria, a land dominated by forests, rivers and mist-covered valleys. Their main settlement is built around a great valley, with smaller villages, training grounds and watch posts scattered throughout the surrounding territory.

Rather than one enormous fortress, their territory is interconnected by temples, monasteries, fortified villages, and secluded training grounds. The central settlement serves as both the political and spiritual heart of the order. It is here that the great masters teach; warriors' trains, scholars conduct their studies, and important decisions concerning the eastern frontier are made.

The relative peace of the region has allowed the Jade Wardens to cultivate something that the other orders rarely have the luxury of pursuing: time. Time to study, train, understand, and prepare.

Culture

The culture of the Jade Wardens is built around the belief that true strength begins within. They've developed a culture centered around discipline, self-mastery and understanding. A warrior is expected to develop both body and mind. Physical training is only one part of their education.

Meditation, philosophy, spiritual studies, history, monster anatomy, and the study of supernatural forces are all considered valuable forms of knowledge. Their temples and training halls therefore often serve multiple purposes. A place of meditation can also be a library; a monastery can contain a training ground; a scholar may also be a warrior, and a warrior may eventually become a teacher.

Knowledge is not considered separate from combat. Knowledge is what allows combat to become mastery.

Philosophy

The Jade Wardens believe that uncontrolled strength is ultimately weakness. A warrior who cannot control their fear, anger, pride, or desire is considered vulnerable regardless of how powerful they may be. Their philosophy revolves around balance. Body and spirit, strength and restraint, knowledge and action, life and death. The

Wardens do not seek to eliminate emotion. Instead, they believe emotion must be understood before it can be mastered.

This philosophy extends to their study of monsters. Rather than seeing every supernatural creature as nothing more than an enemy, the Wardens seek to understand what a creature is, why it behaves as it does and what forces shape it.

The believe understanding an enemy does not mean sympathizing with it. It means becoming capable of defeating it. Their philosophy could be summarized as:

A blade without discipline is no different from the beast it seeks to kill.

The Way of the Spirit

One of the defining characteristics of the Jade Wardens is their study of the spirit. For generations, their monks, scholars and mystics have studied questions that other orders rarely have the time or inclination to investigate: What separates body from soul, what remains after death, what allows supernatural beings to persist beyond the destruction of their bodies, can the spirit be strengthened…

Their studies are not necessarily considered forbidden. They are simply **dangerous**. The Wardens maintain strict traditions concerning what knowledge may be pursued and how it may be used. This has created a culture in which spiritual disciplines are considered an essential part of understanding the supernatural world.

Attitude

Jade Wardens tend to be disciplined, patient, reserved, observant, respectful, introspective, highly traditional and slow to act without understanding the situation. They generally avoid unnecessary confrontation. A Warden does not rush into battle simply because an enemy appears. They observe, assess, prepare, and then strike. This can sometimes cause friction with the other orders, particularly warriors who believe hesitation gives monsters time to grow stronger.

Most Common Classes:

Monk

Fighter

Ranger

Rogue

Cleric

Wizard

Weapons & Equipment

Jade Wardens' equipment emphasizes precision, balance, and craftmanship. Their arsenal includes curved swords, polearms, bows, short blades, spears, staff, and specialized weapons designed around particular martial disciplines.

Their equipment often incorporates jade lacquered wood, silk, engraved metal, and other materials associated with their culture. Weapons are not merely tools. A warrior is expected to develop a relationship with their weapon through years of practice. A master may use the same weapon for decades.

The Emerald Path

The Jade Wardens have their own rite through which an apprentice becomes a full Warden. The candidate must face a challenge specifically designed to expose their greatest weakness. Fear, anger, pride, doubt, attachment.

The exact challenge differs between individuals. The purpose is not necessarily to overcome the weakness completely, but it is to recognize it. A Warden who understands their weakness can control it. A Warden who refuses to acknowledge it will eventually be controlled by it.

Relationship with Monsters

The Jade Wardens possess perhaps the most academic approach to monsters among the four orders. They maintain extensive records concerning supernatural creatures, documenting behavior, anatomy, weaknesses, origins, magical properties, spiritual characteristics, and historical encounters.

Some creatures have been studied for generations. This knowledge is shared carefully with the other Frontier Orders when necessary, The Jade Wardens believe that every encounter with a monster is an opportunity to learn something that may save lives in the future.

Their libraries therefore contain centuries of accumulated knowledge.

Current Leader

Daichi Ren – The current monk Grandmaster of the Jade Wardens.



Chapter 3: The South - The Sunforged Legion

Territory

The Sunforged Legion occupies the southern regions of Kythoria, where the landscape is warmer and more temperate than the northern frontier. Its territory contains vast plains, fertile valleys, ancient ruins, mountains, and several major settlements connected by roads and military routes.

At the heart of the Legion's territory stands its greatest settlement and seat of power. Unlike the Skallfang's fortified frontier settlement or the secluded sanctuaries of the Jade Wardens, the Sunforged capital resembles a vast imperial city. Massive stone structures dominate the skyline, colonnades surround public squares, statues commemorate legendary warriors and scholars, libraries, academies, laboratories and military institutions occupy entire districts.

At the center stands the **Legion's Grand Forum**, where military, political and scholarly matters are discussed. The city is simultaneously a fortress, academy and center of research.

Culture

Sunforged culture is heavily influenced by ancient ideals of civilization, military discipline, philosophy, and scholarship. They believe that civilization survives not simply through strength, but through its ability to preserve knowledge and pass it to the next generation.

Education is therefore highly valued. Children showing particular talent may be taken into academies where they can study history, philosophy, medicine, monster anatomy, magic, engineering, military strategy, natural sciences and the supernatural.

The Legion has produced some of the greatest scholars, physicians, historians, and researchers in Kythoria. However, knowledge is never completely separated from military service. Even scholars are expected to understand the threat beyond the frontier. After all, the Legion's greatest principle is that: To understand the enemy is to deny the enemy the advantage of the unknown.

Philosophy

The Sunforged Legion believes that knowledge is humanity's greatest weapon. The Scourge has survived for centuries partly because mortal civilizations repeatedly encountered creatures and supernatural forces they did not understand.

The Legion intends to change that. Every monster encountered can teach them something, every battle can reveal a weakness, every corpse can contain information, and every magical phenomenon can potentially be studied. Their philosophy is therefore built around three principals: Observe, Understand, Adapt.

They do not believe knowledge should simply be accumulated; it must be used. A discovery that remains locked inside a library while people die on the frontier is considered incomplete. The ultimate purpose of the scholarship is to make civilization stronger.

The Grand Academies

One of the greatest achievements of the Sunforged Legion is its network of academies. Young scholars from across Kythoria travel south to study under the Legion's greatest masters. Some remain scholars throughout their entire lives.

Others become researchers, physicians, engineers, military strategists, or magical practitioners. The most talented may eventually become members of the Legion itself. This had made the Sunforged territories a destination for intellectuals from all over the continent. The Legion does not simply produce warriors. It produces the people who will eventually teach Kythoria how to survive.

The Monster Archives

The Legion maintains enormous archives dedicated to the study of the Scourge. Every creature that can be documented is catalogued. Records may contain anatomy, behavior, habitat, weaknesses, magical abilities, reproductive patterns, known variations, historical encounters, and recommended methods of engagement. Most of this information was gathered by the Skallfang Clan hunters and documented by the legionnaires of the Sunforged.

Particularly dangerous creatures are preserved in specialized containment facilities for further study. The Legion's archives are considered among the most valuable repositories of knowledge in Kythoria.

The Corps of Study

The Sunforged Legion is divided into several specialized branches. One of the most respected is the Scholar's Corps, composed of researchers, historians, physicians, alchemists and arcane scholars.

Another is the Legionary Corps, responsible for military operations and defense. There are also specialists dedicated to magical research, engineering, medicine, monster anatomy, alchemy, archaeology, and battlefield logistics.

Attitude

Sunforged members tend to be disciplined, educated, confident, curious, analytical, ambitious, proud and sometimes overly confident of their own knowledge. They generally prefer preparation over improvisation. A Sunforged officer wants maps, reports, numbers, and intelligence before committing forces. A scholar wants to reproduce an experiment before declaring a discovery true.

Most Common Classes

Fighter

Paladin

Wizard

Artificer

Cleric

Bard

Weapons & Equipment

Sunforged military equipment favor spears, short swords, shields, bows, polearms and standardized military equipment.

Armor is designed to be functional but also represents rank. Officers often carry decorated armor, crests, or cloaks identifying their position. Scholars and researchers have their own equipment, including alchemical tools, surgical instruments, magical implements, notebooks, measuring devices, specimen containers, and specialized equipment for monster research.

The Sunforged Scholarship

The Sunforged Scholarship is fundamentally different from the other orders. A candidate is not required simply to defeat an opponent. They are given a problem. It may be a military scenario, a monster encounter, a medical emergency, a strategic challenge, or a complex academic problem.

The candidate must demonstrate their ability to think under pressure. Knowledge without action is insufficient. Action without understanding is equally insufficient. The Legion seeks individuals capable of combining both. The ideal Sunforged warrior is therefore not simply strong. They are capable of understanding why they fight.

Relationship with Monsters

The Sunforged Legion has the most scientific relationship with monsters among the four orders. They do not romanticize them nor necessarily fear them. They study them. Monster corpses are often transported from the frontlines to Sunforged laboratories, where teams of scholars dissect, analyze and document them.

This has occasionally created controversy. Some members of the other orders believe the Legion sometimes becomes too fascinated with the things it studies. The Legion's response is simple: What we understand cannot surprise us.

Their research has produced countless discoveries about the Scourge. But some knowledge has also led them into areas that perhaps should have remained unexplored.

Current Leader

Marcellus Aurelius is the current Maximus of the Sunforged Legion and direct descendant of Cassian Aurelius, present in the battle against Khar'Zul.



Chapter 4: The West - The Tidebound Brotherhood

Territory

The Tidebound Brotherhood's territory lies along the western coast of Kythoria and extends deep into the surrounding seas. Unlike the other orders, their frontier is not defined by a single border. The sea is their frontier.

Their settlements were built around ports, islands, fortified harbors, and coastal strongholds. The greatest of these settlements were built around ports, islands, fortified harbors, and coastal strongholds.

The greatest of these settlements served as the heart of the Brotherhood – a massive port where ships from across Kythoria could be found alongside vessels belonging to the Brotherhood itself.

Its docks were crowded with sailors, merchants, hunters, mercenaries, and adventurers. Taverns stood beside shipyards. Bounty boards stood beside markets, and warehouses stood beside training yards.

It was a place where someone could arrive with nothing and leave with a ship, a crew, and a contract. Or arrive as a wanted criminal and disappear into the crowd.

Culture

Tidebound culture revolves around freedom, reputation, and the sea. They are not particularly interested in where someone came from. What matters is what they can do. A noble who cannot handle themselves on a ship is worth little to a Tidebound crew. A former criminal who can navigate a storm, track a monster and keep their crew alive may earn enormous respect.

Their culture is therefore unusually diverse. Different crews may have completely different traditions, beliefs, and methods. There is no single way to be Tidebound. The Brotherhood's identity comes from belonging to something larger than oneself while retaining the freedom to live according to one's own code.

Philosophy

The Tidebound believe that freedom is worth fighting for. They distrust institutions that demand absolute obedience. Kings, governments, religious authorities and even the other Frontier Orders.

They have spent centuries dealing with people who attempt to control the sea and the people who live upon it. The Brotherhood's philosophy can essentially be summarized as: No chain holds those who know how to sail.

However, their concept of freedom has always been morally complicated. To some, freedom means refusing tyranny. To others, it means doing whatever they want. This distinction has caused much of the Brotherhood's controversial history.

The Brotherhood's Code

Unlike the other orders, the Tidebound do not possess a rigid philosophical doctrine. Instead, individual crews traditionally follow their own codes. Nevertheless, several

principles have become almost universally respected: A crew protects its own, a debt must be repaid, a contract must be honored, no one owns the sea.

These principles are not always followed perfectly but breaking them can destroy someone's reputation within the Brotherhood and reputation is one of the most valuable currencies a Tidebound member possesses.

Attitude

Tidebound members tend to be independent, charismatic, adventurous, irreverent, unpredictable, opportunistic, fiercely loyal to their crews, suspicious of authority and comfortable operating outside conventional morality.

They are often more willing than the other orders to take risks.

Controversies

The Tidebound Brotherhood has never had a spotless history. Throughout the centuries, individual crews have been accused of raiding, piracy, smuggling, illegal salvage, black-market trade, contract killing and operating outside the authority of kingdoms.

The Brotherhood has occasionally fought against these practices internally, particularly when they threatened the organization's reputation or endangered innocent civilians. But it has never completely eliminated them.

This has created a complicated relationship between the Brotherhood and the governments of Kythoria. They are often considered criminals. Yet when a monster attacks a remote coastal settlement, those same governments may still turn to them for help.

Most Common Classes

Rogue

Artificer

Ranger

Fighter

Barbarian

Sorcerer

Weapons & Equipment

Tidebound equipment is defined by practicality and adaptability. Their weapons commonly include cutlasses, longswords, rapiers, daggers, handaxes, pistols, bows, crossbows, harpoons and improvised weapons. Armor is generally lighter than that of the Sunforged Legion.

Mobility is essential aboard ships. A Tidebound warrior must be able to fight on a deck, climb rigging, swim, board another vessel and survive being thrown into the sea.

The Rite of Passage

The Tidebound do not have a single standardized rite shared by the entire Brotherhood. Instead, a recruit must earn the acceptance and respect of their crew. Traditionally, this means being entrusted with a task that tests their ability to survive without someone constantly protecting them.

For some, it may be their first bounty. For others, an expedition into dangerous waters...

The specific challenge does not matter; what matters is returning with a story worth telling.

Relationship with Monsters

The Tidebound have a highly pragmatic relationship with monsters. They see monsters as threats, targets, and opportunities. A monster threatening a village is a bounty; a dangerous creature aboard a ship is a problem.

The Brotherhood is willing to work with creatures that the other orders would never tolerate. This has made them particularly effective in situations where conventional rules have failed.

Current Captain

Bromm Blackpowder – A dwarf gunslinger fighter who is the captain of the largest crew within the Brotherhood.


FREEDOM
BOUNTIES
NO BORDERS
SAME SEAS
NEW HUNTS
WE RETURN
BOUNTIES
CREWS
CONTRACTS
SURVIVAL